DISCORD THREAT ASSESSMENT

The Alphabet Cartel — Platform Migration Documentation

Document Version: v3.0 | **Created:** 2026-02-20 | **Last Updated:** 2026-03-05

Status: **Active Concern — Developments through March 5, 2026**

Version History: v1.0 (2026-02-20) — Original assessment. v2.0 (2026-02-25) — Persona exposure, ImmigrationOS/ELITE, Discord delay. v3.0 (2026-03-05) — Teen-by-default live, K-ID vendor swap, DHS subpoena surge confirmed, $85B ICE apparatus, behavioral profiling active now.

1. Purpose

This document summarizes the concrete, documented threats that Discord's recent policy changes and government entanglements pose to members of The Alphabet Cartel. It is intended to inform staff and help communicate the urgency of our platform migration to the broader community.

These are not hypothetical risks. Every threat described below is active, documented, and has continued developing since this assessment was first written in February 2026.

How to read this document: Each major section follows a consistent structure — what we assessed originally, followed by what has since been confirmed or worsened. The original arguments were sound when written. The new findings validate them and, in several areas, substantially raise the stakes. We have not replaced our original analysis; we have built on it.

2. Mandatory Age Verification — Now Partially Live

What We Originally Assessed

In early February 2026, Discord announced all users would be placed into a teen-appropriate experience by default. To escape restrictions — content filtering, limited DMs, no Stage channel access — flagged users would need to submit either a facial scan or a government-issued photo ID through a third-party verification vendor. We assessed this as an unacceptable surveillance pipeline that TAC members should not be compelled to participate in.

What Has Since Been Confirmed (v3.0)

Teen-by-default restrictions are partially live as of March 2026. The age verification prompt for most users is delayed to H2 2026, but the default restrictions are not. All Discord accounts are being reclassified into teen-restricted mode in a phased rollout that began in early March 2026.

The behavioral profiling is already running. Discord's age inference model is actively analyzing every member's account right now — account tenure, payment methods on file, server membership patterns, activity timing, and behavioral signals. This profiling is not paused pending the H2 2026 rollout. It is live.

Multiple independent sources have confirmed that Discord's teen-by-default policy disproportionately impacts LGBTQ+ communities specifically because these communities apply age-restricted settings to create safe adult spaces — even for non-sexual content. Our community structure means our members are more likely to be caught by verification gates than the average Discord user.

Why Voluntary Was Never Reassuring

Discord is not legally required to implement age verification globally. Other major platforms including Reddit have fought age verification legislation in court. Discord chose to build this infrastructure ahead of any mandate. The Electronic Frontier Foundation stated there is no reason for Discord to comply in advance with laws that have not been passed or enforced against them. The behavioral profiling component is running right now.

3. The Persona Exposure — A Surveillance Stack Hiding in Plain Sight

What We Originally Assessed

We documented that Persona Identities, Inc. — Discord's age verification vendor for a UK test — was a comprehensive KYC/AML surveillance platform. In February 2026, security researchers found Persona's frontend code publicly accessible on a FedRAMP-authorized US government endpoint, exposing the full scope of what the system was doing to users.

The Full Scope of What Was Confirmed

The exposed code showed Persona performing 269 distinct verification checks per user, including:

- Facial recognition against watchlists and lists of politically exposed persons (PEPs)
- Adverse media screening across 14 categories including terrorism and espionage
- Risk and similarity scoring on submitted identities
- Selfie analytics: suspicious-entity detection, pose repeat detection, age inconsistency flags
- **Data retention of up to three years** for IP addresses, browser fingerprints, device fingerprints, government ID numbers, phone numbers, names, and faces

Discord told users biometric data would not leave their device. A deleted UK disclaimer stated data would leave the device and be stored for up to seven days. The Persona files showed retention of up to three years — a direct contradiction of Discord's public reassurances.

The exposed code sat on a FedRAMP-authorized endpoint — meaning Persona is actively pursuing compliance infrastructure to sell identity verification directly to US federal agencies. A domain (withpersona-gov.com) was identified potentially querying an OpenAI government database. Persona's COO denied partnerships with federal agencies. The FedRAMP endpoint tells a more complicated story.

4. Vendor Swap: Persona Out, K-ID In — The Architecture Is Unchanged

New in v3.0

Discord has replaced Persona with K-ID as its primary global age verification vendor. Dropping Persona specifically is a meaningful response to the specific concerns about Persona's surveillance depth and FedRAMP ambitions.

What Did Not Change

- **The structural architecture is identical:** identity documents still pass through a third-party vendor; a human-verified fallback for failed estimations still exists — and it was this fallback pathway that was exploited in the 2025 breach
- **K-ID is not a neutral party:** K-ID is also used by Meta and Snap — it is a major identity data aggregator holding verification relationships across a significant portion of the major social platform ecosystem
- **The behavioral age inference model is unchanged and already running:** Discord built and operates this entirely in-house; it profiles every user regardless of vendor changes
- **The EFF assessment is unchanged:** the vendor swap is "an improvement" but "doesn't eliminate the underlying potential for data breaches and other harms"

The decision to leave Discord does not hinge on which vendor Discord is currently using. It hinges on the fact that Discord is building this pipeline at all.

5. The 2025 Data Breach

In late 2024/early 2025, Discord disclosed that attackers accessed a third-party vendor's systems used for age-related appeals, exposing approximately 70,000 users' government-issued ID photos and associated sensitive personal data. Discord won the EFF's 2025 "We Still Told You So" Breachies Award for this incident.

Discord's official figure is approximately 70,000 affected accounts. Attackers claimed up to 2.1 million ID photos were exfiltrated. The third-party service Discord alleged was responsible vigorously denied ever handling government IDs for Discord. This contradiction has never been publicly resolved.

The architecture persists. Discord states it no longer routes ID uploads through general support infrastructure. But K-ID includes a human-verified fallback for failed facial estimations. It was precisely the human-verified fallback pathway in the original system that created the breach. A new vendor with a similar architectural pattern resets the clock — it does not eliminate the risk class.

6. The Palantir / ICE Connection — Now an $85 Billion Surveillance Machine

What We Originally Assessed

We documented the investment relationship between Persona, Founders Fund (Peter Thiel's venture firm), and Palantir — and that Palantir operates ICE's core investigative infrastructure. We assessed this as a concerning chain of custody from Discord identity data to immigration enforcement.

What Has Since Been Confirmed — The Scale Is Dramatically Larger

- **ImmigrationOS ($30M contract, active through September 2027):** AI-driven platform for immigration enforcement — targeting and prioritization, self-deportation tracking with near-real-time visibility, full lifecycle management. Pulls from passport records, SSNs, IRS data, Medicaid records, DMV files, utility bills, court records, and license-plate reader data.
- **ELITE (Enhanced Leads Identification & Targeting for Enforcement):** functions like Google Maps populated with people instead of restaurants. ICE agents draw shapes on a map to identify target-rich areas for raids. Each person has a dossier with photo, address, and a confidence score predicting their current location — derived from Medicaid address updates and federal data. Normal safeguards may be disabled during special operations.

The $85 Billion ICE arsenal (confirmed by multiple investigative outlets):

- Palantir ELITE: confidence scores and geospatial targeting from Medicaid and federal databases
- Mobile Fortify: facial recognition against a database of 1.2 billion photos
- Zignal Labs: monitoring of 8 billion social media posts per day
- BI2 iris scanners matching against 5 million records
- Cell-site simulators tracking phones in real time
- Drones capable of identifying people from 7.5 miles away

> These tools are not siloed — they feed into each other. The database of 1.2 billion faces includes US citizens. Social media monitoring at 8 billion posts per day captures everyone who posts. Cell-site simulators grab every phone in range. Stephen Miller — Trump's chief architect of immigration enforcement — holds a substantial financial stake in Palantir.

The Chain of Custody — v3.0

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Discord age verification data + behavioral profiling
    → K-ID (current vendor) / Persona (former, Founders Fund-backed)
        → Founders Fund (major investor in both Persona and Palantir)
            → Palantir ($900M+ in federal contracts since Trump took office)
                → ImmigrationOS / ELITE (active ICE targeting platform)
                    → $85B ICE surveillance apparatus
                        → Deportation targeting of individuals identified via AI
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7. DHS Subpoenas — Discord Named, Hundreds Issued, Targeting Speech Like Ours

What We Originally Assessed

We assessed that DHS administrative subpoenas — no judicial approval required — represented a live threat to TAC members, and that Discord had been named among platforms receiving such subpoenas.

What Has Since Been Confirmed — This Is Significantly Worse

Hundreds of subpoenas, no judicial oversight. DHS issued hundreds of administrative subpoenas to Google, Meta, Reddit, and Discord demanding names, email addresses, phone numbers, and other identifying data for accounts that criticized ICE, reported ICE agent locations, or tracked immigration enforcement activity. Previously used sparingly for serious crimes — now deployed against political speech.

Google, Meta, and Reddit have confirmed compliance with at least some requests. Discord has declined to comment — which is not the same as refusing.

Documented cases:

- A Pennsylvania bilingual Facebook page posting ICE checkpoint locations to 10,000 followers — Meta subpoenaed in September 2025, users given 10-14 days to challenge
- A retired Google user who sent a polite email criticizing an asylum case — subpoenaed within five hours, DHS agents arrived at his home weeks later
- **At least one Google subpoena had the "suspected violation" field left entirely blank —** Google fulfilled it the same day it notified the user, leaving zero practical time to challenge

Why The Alphabet Cartel is directly in the frame: We are an LGBTQIA+ advocacy community. We discuss political issues. We have members who are immigrants or advocate for immigrant communities. We post about immigration enforcement. We are exactly the profile these subpoenas target. Member usernames, email addresses, IP logs, and account metadata already exist on Discord's servers and are accessible via this mechanism — with no warrant and a challenge window that can be effectively zero in practice.

8. Discord's Response — Delay, Not Reversal

Discord's CTO Stanislav Vishnevskiy published a blog post on February 24, 2026 outlining commitments. Here is the current status of each:

Commitment	Status
Global verification prompt rollout delayed to H2 2026	☑ Confirmed
Persona partnership ended	☑ Confirmed — replaced with K-ID
Vendor transparency list published before global launch	⏳ Not yet published
Technical documentation for age inference model	⏳ Not yet published
Behavioral profiling paused during delay	⭕ Not done — running now
Default restrictions rolled back	⭕ Not done — rolling out now

Discord's CTO wrote: "Many of you are worried that this is just another big tech company finding new ways to collect your personal data. I get that skepticism. It's earned... But that's not what we're doing."

The acknowledgment that the skepticism is earned is accurate. The claim that Discord is an exception is not supported by the evidence. The delay changes the timeline. It does not change the structural situation. One analysis put it plainly: "The delay buys Discord time to execute on these commitments. It also buys time for the story to fade from the news cycle."

9. Impact on LGBTQIA+ Members Specifically

What We Originally Assessed

We documented four specific vectors of harm: trans and nonbinary members misidentified by facial estimation tools; members who rely on pseudonymity; members with immigration concerns; and members engaged in political advocacy.

What Has Since Been Confirmed and Strengthened

- **Disproportionate LGBTQIA+ impact independently confirmed:** multiple sources document that Discord's teen-by-default policy disproportionately impacts LGBTQ+ communities because these communities apply age-restricted settings to create safe adult spaces even for non-sexual content
- **The political advocacy vector is now a live threat:** the DHS subpoena surge targets political speech about immigration enforcement at the exact platforms where TAC members have been active
- **The immigration concern vector is more concrete:** 8 billion social media posts monitored per day means content our members posted about immigration, ICE operations, and related advocacy may already be in surveillance systems
- **Trans and nonbinary members face doubled exposure:** facial estimation misidentification pushes those members to the manual ID verification pathway — the same pathway that was compromised in the 2025 breach, and where government IDs may not match presented identity

10. Summary: The Threat Model

The risks are not theoretical. They are documented, current, and active — and have materially worsened at every update to this document.

Threat	Status	v3.0 Update
Teen-by-default restrictions rolling out globally	🔴 Live now	Partial rollout began March 2026; not delayed
Behavioral age profiling running on all users	🔴 Active now	Confirmed running during the H2 2026 'delay'
Age verification prompts (H2 2026)	🔴 Coming	Delayed, not cancelled
Persona conducted 269 surveillance checks including watchlist screening	🔴 Confirmed	Discord ended Persona; practices confirmed via code exposure
Vendor swap to K-ID does not fix structural vulnerability	🔴 Confirmed	EFF: an improvement, but doesn't eliminate the underlying harms
2025 breach of 70,000 users' government IDs	🔴 Occurred	Scope disputed; fallback architecture unchanged in K-ID
Founders Fund investment link (Persona → Palantir)	🔴 Confirmed	Original chain of custody accurate and now widely reported
ImmigrationOS: $30M ICE AI targeting platform	🔴 Active	Draws from Medicaid, SSN, IRS, DMV, license plate data
ELITE: geospatial deportation targeting tool	🔴 Active	Confidence scores; safeguards can be disabled for 'special operations'
$85B ICE surveillance arsenal	🔴 Operational	1.2B face database; 8B social media posts/day monitored
Stephen Miller financial stake in Palantir	🔴 Confirmed	Policy architect has personal financial interest in contract growth
DHS subpoenas targeting political speech	🔴 Escalating	Hundreds issued; Google, Meta, Reddit confirmed compliant; Discord silent
Blank-field subpoenas fulfilled same-day	🔴 Documented	At least one Google subpoena: violation field blank, fulfilled immediately
LGBTQIA+ communities disproportionately impacted	🔴 Confirmed	Age-gated community structure creates higher verification exposure
Facial estimation unreliable for trans/nonbinary members	🔴 Documented	Misidentification routes to manual ID pathway; that pathway was breached
Discord's response: delay not reversal	🟠 Ongoing	Behavioral profiling and default restrictions not paused

We made the right decision to move to Fluxer. The situation has worsened at every update to this document. The delay to H2 2026 confirms Discord is still planning to build exactly what we

assessed as unacceptable — while already running behavioral profiling and rolling out restrictions that affect our community. Our community is on Fluxer. That is where we should be.

11. Sources

Age Verification & Persona

Discord Voluntarily Pushes Mandatory Age Verification — EFF, Feb 12, 2026
Age verification vendor Persona left frontend exposed — Malwarebytes, Feb 20, 2026
Discord distances itself from Peter Thiel–backed verification software — Fortune, Feb 24, 2026
Getting Global Age Assurance Right — Discord CTO blog, Feb 24, 2026
Discord Delays Global Age Verification to H2 2026: What Changed and What Didn't — Redact, 2026

DHS Subpoenas

DHS Sends Subpoenas to Google, Meta, Reddit, and Discord — IBTimes UK, Feb 14, 2026
Homeland Security reportedly sent hundreds of subpoenas — TechCrunch, Feb 14, 2026
DHS demanded personal information about ICE's critics from Discord, Reddit, Google, and Meta — PC Gamer, Feb 17, 2026

Palantir / ICE Surveillance

ICE to Use ImmigrationOS by Palantir — American Immigration Council, 2025
ELITE: The Palantir App ICE Uses to Find Neighborhoods to Raid — 404 Media, Jan 2026
Inside ICE's $85 Billion Arsenal: Every Surveillance Tool — State of Surveillance, Feb 2026
ICE alleged to use Palantir-developed tool that uses Medicaid data — Fortune, Jan 26, 2026

Built with care for chosen family